

Make the composite believable

Multimedia 12 • layers, masks, light and revision



Constructed practice result; not a software-control screenshot

Check relationships before adding effects.

Your edits must remain recoverable.

TRY • 2 MIN Identify one relationship you would inspect before adding a glow.

Believability checks

Look for evidence that the images share a scene.



Constructed practice result; not a software-control screenshot

Scale and perspective.

Light direction, colour and intensity.

Edges, contact/cast shadows and texture.

TRY · 2 MIN Name two specific visible relationships you would test. Avoid “it looks fake” as the whole diagnosis.

A recoverable layer stack

Keep content and edits separate.

Editable Type

Source image or Smart Object.

Adjustment + its mask

A mask for visible area.

Subject + visibility mask

Adjustment layers for tone or colour.

Source image / Smart Object

Editable type above the intended image treatment.

TRY · 2 MIN The director asks for a lighter subject tomorrow. Which source control should remain available?

Selections and layer masks

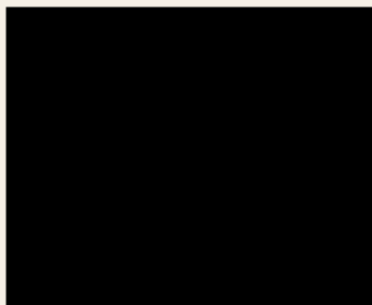
A selection identifies an area; a mask controls visibility.



White: reveal



Grey: partial



Black: hide

Select the subject before adding a mask.

White reveals; black hides; grey gives partial visibility.

Select the mask thumbnail before painting the mask.

Concept model of mask values; not Photoshop UI

TRY • 2 MIN Explain how to recover an area hidden by a black mark on the mask.

Masking practice in Photoshop

Make a reversible edge decision.



Constructed practice result; not a software-control screenshot

Select the image layer; use Select → Subject.

Inspect the selection, then add a layer mask.

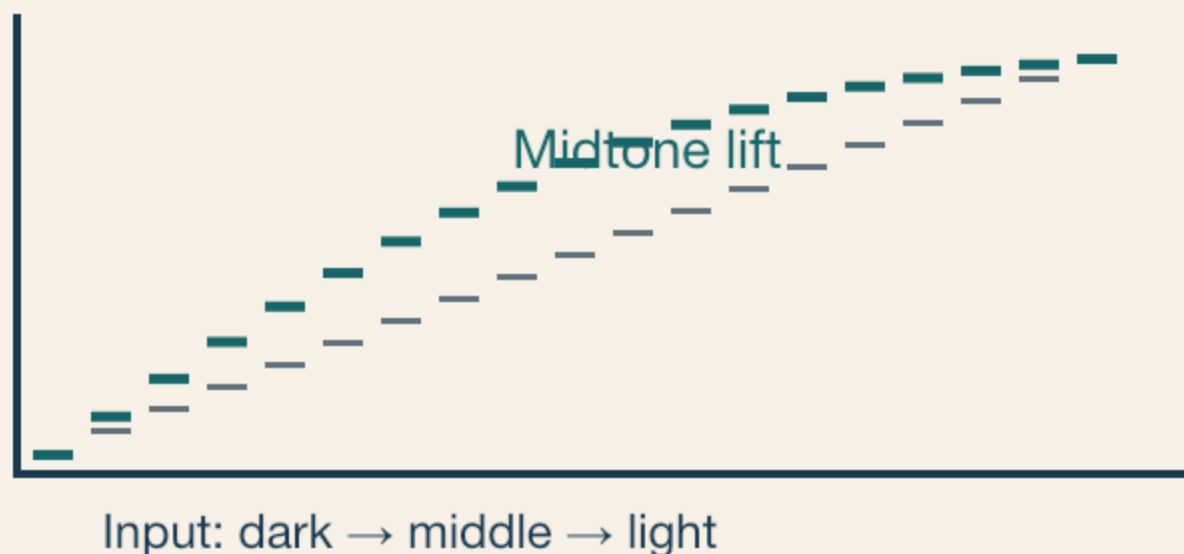
Use a soft brush on the selected mask where an edge needs repair.

TRY · 2 MIN On a permitted practice image, hide and recover one small area using a mask. Retain the before/after.

Adjustment layers

Change tone while keeping the source available.

Output brightness ↑



Layer → New Adjustment Layer → Curves.

Change the curve; inspect the image.

Toggle the adjustment to compare the result.

TRY · 2 MIN Predict which tonal region changes when you lift a midtone point. Compare before and after.

Clipping and masks have different jobs

Constrain an adjustment to a layer, then refine its area.

Base layer	Defines the clipping extent
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A clipping relationship uses the base layer's visible content.

Adjustment	Changes tone / colour
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An adjustment mask controls where that adjustment contributes.

Its mask	Refines where that change applies
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Both can be useful in one recoverable edit.

TRY · 2 MIN A subject adjustment also changes the background. What relationship would you inspect?

Motivated light

Decide where the light comes from before painting it.



Constructed practice result; not a software-control screenshot

Locate the source or plausible direction.

Identify surfaces facing and turning away from it.

Keep brightness, shadow and colour relationships coherent.

TRY · 2 MIN Point to the light cue and identify one surface that should respond differently from another.

Light, shadow and edges

An effect should support the scene you established.



Constructed practice result; not a software-control screenshot

Contact shadows anchor touching surfaces.

Cast shadows depend on the light and receiving surface.

Rim light requires a suitable light direction.

TRY · 2 MIN Identify one edge that would need checking if the light source moved.

Diagnose one fault at a time

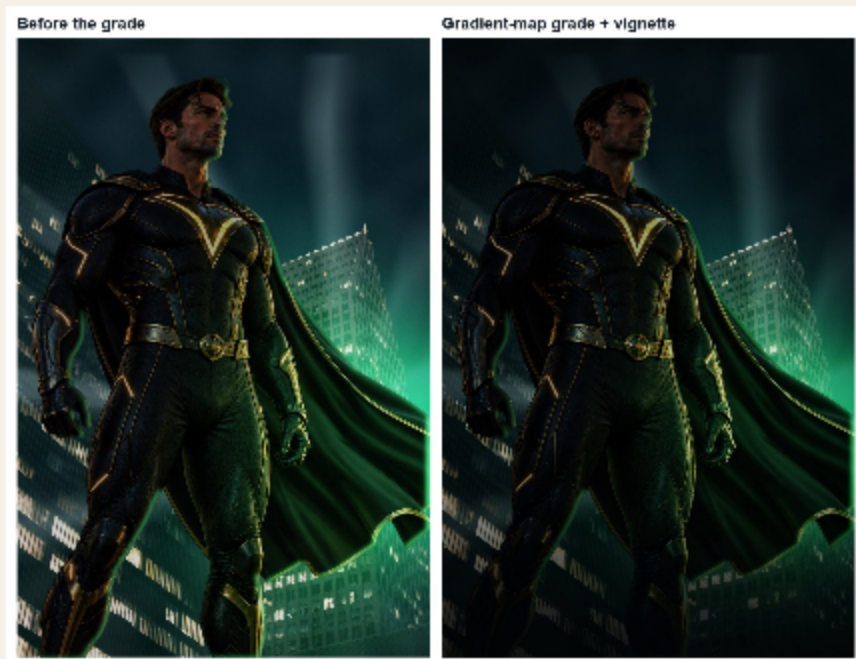
Use evidence → likely cause → targeted repair → check.

OBSERVE	Name one visible fault	Isolate one visible inconsistency.
REPAIR	Inspect and change one control	Inspect the relevant layer and control.
VERIFY	Compare at the same view	Keep other variables stable for the comparison.

TRY · 2 MIN Write a four-part diagnosis for a visible fault in your own work.

Grade with a purpose

A shared treatment should retain useful information.



Constructed practice result; not a software-control screenshot

Compare before and after at the same view.

Check skin, neutral areas and title/background interaction.

Keep the global grade separate from local repairs.

TRY · 2 MIN Name one detail you would protect and one relationship you would adjust.

Documented demonstration

Watch which control changes which area.

PREDICT What will the control change?

WATCH Pause at a visible comparison

EXPLAIN Control → change → consequence

Open Adobe's adjustment-layer demonstration.

Pause when an adjustment or mask changes.

Explain the difference between its control and its visible result.

TRY · 2 MIN Predict whether the adjustment affects the whole image or a masked area before the change.

Production practice

Apply one taught method to your own concept.

PLAN Three distinct alternatives

CREATE Two treatments for one direction

JUSTIFY Audience + purpose + evidence

Build a minimum viable composite.

Repair one edge and one light/tone relationship.

Retain named layers and a visible comparison.

TRY • 20 MIN Work for 20 minutes, then show a recoverable edit and explain why you used it.

Changed conditions

The taught method must survive a new requirement.

RE-READ

Changed director's brief

Return to the brief before changing the image.

PREDICT

Relationships that need revision

Predict which relationships need revision.

CHECK

Source controls + before / after

Make and verify the changes using your own source file.

TRY · 2 MIN For a practice-only change, identify affected relationships and make a justified revision.

Save, reopen and inspect

A delivered image and an editable master have different jobs.

SOURCE	Layered editable PSD	Keep a layered PSD with named controls.
EXPORT	Checked viewing image	Export the viewing image at the required dimensions.
EVIDENCE	Plan + comparisons + credits	Reopen both and inspect the visible result.

TRY · 2 MIN Show the reopened master, identify one adjustment and inspect the exported image outside Photoshop.

Retrieve, explain and revisit

A finished image is one part of the evidence.

RECALL Explain without your notes

TRANSFER Apply to a fresh image

RETURN Revise your own decision

Selection versus mask.

Adjustment versus source pixels.

Clipping versus local mask.

Next class: diagnose a fresh composite without notes.

TRY · 2 MIN Explain two distinctions and name one visible test of believable lighting.